

What else to watch: *Trouble in Paradise* (1932) ■ *Ninotchka* (1939) ■ *The Shop Around the Corner* (1940) ■ *Heaven Can Wait* (1943) ■ *That Lady in Ermine* (1948)

Stack), she is drawn into a plan to track down a German spy who is about to endanger the Polish Resistance network. In a rapidly escalating farce, the actors (many of them Jewish) use their skills at disguise to fool the invading Nazis.

Dark comedy

This sounds as much like the premise of a dark, intricate spy thriller as the light, romantic comedies for which Lubitsch was known, which is exactly what the director intended: a satire/comedy with dark intent. Lubitsch claimed that he wanted to steer clear of two traditional comedic formulas: "Drama with comedy relief and comedy with dramatic relief. I had



Ernst Lubitsch Director

Born in Berlin in 1892, Ernst Lubitsch joined the Deutsches Theater in 1911. Two years later he made his screen debut in *The Ideal Wife*, but by 1920 his focus shifted to directing. He left for the US in 1922 to direct Mary Pickford in the hit movie *Rosita*, and made a smooth transition into sound. With *Trouble in*

Paradise (1935) he found ways to smuggle risqué ideas past the censor: a trick known as "the Lubitsch touch." This paid off in comedies such as *Ninotchka* (1939). He died in 1947 at 55.

Key movies

1940 *The Shop Around the Corner*

1942 *To Be or Not to Be*

“I don’t know, it’s **not convincing**. To me, he’s just **a man with a little moustache**.”

Stage manager / *To Be or Not to Be*



made up my mind to make a picture with no attempt to relieve anybody from anything at any time." The movie succeeds in being both an anti-Fascist tract and,

bizarrely, a showbiz satire (the self-obsessed Tura consoles himself with the thought that an audience member who walks out during his *Hamlet* soliloquy may have been suffering from a heart attack). The war provides the sobering counterpoint to the comedy: people die. There is a double edge to the code message that Sobinski passes to Maria, unwittingly via a double agent. "To be, or not to be," it says, and as the Turas bravely lead their theater troupe in a deadly game of double bluff, it is clear that Lubitsch is using *Hamlet*'s famous line to question a complacent United States. To fight or not to fight, and let the Nazis get away with it? For Lubitsch, this was no question at all. ■

Jewish actor Bronski (Tom Dugan) and the other members of Tura's cast fool the Germans by disguising themselves as Hitler and his entourage.